Israeli army found that a majority of the Druze opposed the decision. Opponents formed a group, the “Free Druze Youth Organization”, which encouraged young men to ignore the draft notices; those who did were sentenced to stiff prison terms. But the leadership saw loyalty to the state as their best guarantee of safety, a pattern the Druze have followed in neighboring countries as well: in Syria, they have remained largely loyal to the Assad regime; the leader of the Lebanese Druze, Walid Jumblatt, is known as the weathervane of his country’s politics.

The small Circassian minority made their own deal two years later, in 1958. (While they are not ethnic Arabs, some of them speak Arabic, owing to the century they spent scattered across the Ottoman Empire after their expulsion from the Caucasus.) Now, Khalloul argued, it was time for the Christians—or at least the Maronites—to do the same. “This is our country. If we don’t defend our country, we will have Syria,” he said.

Enemies and friends

It was a complicated moment for Israel’s Christian community. They were eagerly awaiting a high-profile guest: Pope Francis, the newly-installed and very popular head of the Catholic Church. The Maronite patriarch, Bishara al-Rai, planned to fly from Lebanon to accompany him on his trip, the first such visit by a Maronite leader in half a century. Khalloul and his co-religionists were hoping for an audience.

Francis took office in 2013 after his predecessor’s unexpected resignation and quickly built a reputation as a liberal reformer, at least for a pope: washing the feet of women and Muslims in a ceremony typically reserved for Catholic men, for example. A longtime friend of the Jewish community in his native Buenos Aires, Francis spoke out strongly against anti-Semitism, working to mend the church’s historic schism with the Jews.

Even before he had descended from a Jordanian helicopter at Ben-Gurion International Airport, however, he was already courting controversy in Israel. He started his Middle East tour in Jordan, then flew to the West Bank, where he was due to preside over mass at the Church of the Nativity, the site where Jesus was born. En route to the church, however, his convoy passed by the separation wall, the eight-meter-high concrete barrier that separates Bethlehem from Jerusalem. Francis unexpectedly asked the cars to stop and descended to pray at the barrier. This image—the pope hunched